

Past, Present, Future

Tabitha is way ahead of her time
Dakota is behind the times
Just in time to meet in the middle
as iTab & Coda!

It gives a whole new meaning to
“Right Person, Wrong Time”

STAGE MUSICAL OVERVIEW

Past, Present, Future is a musical adventure romance that follows Tabitha and Dakota, lonely musicians respectively from the 1st Century Middle East and 21st Century Midwest whose guitars carved from spacetime wood trap them in the 19th Century Romantic era. They form the duo ¡Tab & Coda! to survive the wrath of the Timeharmonic Orchestra until they can return to their home timeline, not without together becoming the right people at the wrong time. It explores bittersweet themes like mortality, an appreciation for wisdom, an everlasting search for freshness, and the value of nature in music.

WHY (THEN) NOW (LATER)?

Past, Present, Future speaks to many of our feelings of not fitting into your own era. Seeing a 1st-century woman find her soul in alternative hip-hop while a 21st-century newcomer finds peace in ancient hymns is meant to comfort the audience who feel like an outsider into seeking out musical communities. By blending ancient roots with future sounds, they prove that we can find our people and build a home, even when the timing feels completely wrong. Tabitha and Dakota are like us: they are the right people at the wrong times.

It also matters now when we are all out of sync with the world. We're living in a hyper-digital age where algorithms dictate what we listen to and everything is moving too fast. The Timeharmonic Orchestra personifies that pressure to be perfect and efficient all the time. When ¡Tab & Coda! fight back with instruments made of wood and seeds, the musical is a gentle reminder to unplug, slow down, and remember the human soul behind the art.

Past, Present, Future is *Winner* meets *Millennials are Killing Musicals* meets *Back to the Future* meets *The Time Traveler's Wife*.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

TABITHA is a lyre maker from 1st Century Galilee who is way ahead of her time and in over her head. She seeks that “new sound.” Destiny, the Timepiper of the Future, gifts her American basswood which she uses to build her oud that sends her into the future. Tab finds home in alternative hip hop. As a singer, she is a breath of fresh air to what music could be.

DAKOTA is a guitar maker from 21st Century Free Soil, Michigan who is behind the times. They honor the “oldies.” Frailty, the Timepiper of the Past, gifts them Judean date palm seeds for their guitar, which sends them back in time. Kota finds home in psalmody. As a guitarist, they are an old soul showing what music once was, never staying up to date on the mainstream.

JESSE is the father of Tabitha. **JESSICA** is the mother of Dakota.

TIMEHARMONIC ORCHESTRA

ETERNITY LINGER is the omnipotent Spacetime Bandleader. They lead the Timepipers (the chorus of fate) to run each timeline smoothly but is on the verge of firing the Conductor. Playing the zither and flutes of all kind, they are based on Ling Lun, the legendary founder of music in ancient China.

FRAILITY is the Timepiper of the Past, based on the Norse Norn, Urd. They navigate darkened times as a plover with metallic calls. They are the oldest of the three immortal shapeshifters. They like messing with Reality.

REALITY is the Timepiper of the Present, based on the Norse Norn, Skuld. They trek the rough terrains of spacetime as an upland sandpiper with ethereal whistles. They are the most uptight and suck up to Eternity.

DESTINY is the Timepiper of the Future, based on the Norse Norn, Verdandi. They go with the flow of time as a spotted sandpiper with high-pitched calls. A child, they are the youngest. Like Frailty, they enjoy pranking Reality.

CONDUCTOR is the literal music conductor of the production. They shape how time flows for the time travelers, based on their choice of instruments and musical phrases. Without them, every being (will) dies/died.

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MUSICAL NUMBERS

ACT I

1. Overture / Prologue: The Seeds of Fate Timeharmonic Orchestra
2. Born in the Wrong Generation Tabitha, Dakota, Jesse, Jessica, Ancient People, Modern People
3. The Right Person Tabitha, Dakota
4. The Wrong Time Tabitha, Dakota, Timepipers
5. Father is Long Gone, Mother Ain't Born Yet Tabitha, Dakota
6. Out of Tune Eternity, Timeharmonic Orchestra
7. Must Be Nice (Times Like These) Tabitha, Dakota, Past People
8. Band Together Tabitha, Dakota, Past People
9. Until the Beginning Tabitha, Dakota, Timepipers, People
10. Life is Short (You Must Be This Old to Die) Tabitha, Timepipers
11. Future Plans Tabitha, Dakota, Timeharmonic Orchestra
12. Right Person, Wrong Time Tabitha, Dakota

ACT II

13. Passing By, Running Behind Tabitha, Jessica, Modern People
14. Keep Tabs (on Your Heart) Dakota, Jesse, Ancient People
15. The Songs Linger (Long Enough) Timeharmonic Orchestra
16. Seconds Can't Count Tabitha, Dakota
17. Out of Wack Eternity, Conductor, Timeharmonic Orchestra, Tabitha, Dakota
18. Paradox Company
19. In Loving Destiny Eternity
20. From the End Dakota, Jessica, Tabitha
21. In Loving Destiny (Reprise) Company

★One or two songs will be a David Quang Pham signature science song teaching paleoethnobotany and archaeology.

PLOT SUMMARY

Trapped in the 19th-century Romantic era by guitars carved from spacetime wood, a 1st-century Galilean lyre maker and a lonely 21st-century Midwesterner must fuse ancient hymns with hip hop to survive a cosmic orchestra out to get them and find their way home.

Space and time are in harmony due to the everlasting performance of the Timeharmonic Orchestra, overseen by Eternity Linger and their Timepipers of the Past, Present, and Future named Frailty, Reality, and Destiny. They navigate space and time as birds who drop seeds to keep the timeline rooted (“Over/Prologue: The Seeds of Fate”).

In 1st Century Galilee, Tabitha is a lyre maker trying to revolutionize music that prioritizes individualism and a deep awe of nature over Enlightenment. In 21st Century Free Soil, Michigan, Dakota is a guitar maker who is deeply into the classics (“Born in the Wrong Generation”). Their parents see them as failures who will never find someone (“The Right Person”). Frailty and Destiny, annoyed by Reality’s insistent bossiness, decides to get back at Reality by playing Cupid with Tabitha and Dakota. Destiny grows a American basswood tree which Tabitha uses its wood to carve her oud. Meanwhile, Frailty offers Judean date palm seeds that Dakota implements into their guitar. With a strum, it sends them to the 19th Century (“The Wrong Time”). Tabitha and Dakota do not get along (“Father is Long Gone, Mother Ain’t Born Yet”).

Outside spacetime, Frailty and Destiny watch the timeline grow wonky. Reality scolds them and demands that they get Tabitha and Dakota home or else Eternity will fire the Conductor and restart the timeline (“Out of Tune”).

The Timepipers hop in time to find Tabitha and Dakota playing music to get home. It causes them to jump around years which the Timepipers have trouble catching up musically (“Must Be Nice (Times Like These)”). Tabitha and Dakota’s antics catch the attention of the underground movement as they unintentionally kickstart the Romantic era and inspire the creation of the classical guitar. They form the duo, iTab & Coda! (“Band Together”).

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They start to accept the trajectory they are on, which is none, as they fall for each other ("Until the Beginning"). The Timepipers reach Tabitha and sow seeds of doubt into her ("Life is Short (You Must Be This Old to Die)"). Tabitha wants a future together or technically the past, but Dakota once again does not know themselves. Eternity steps in and rattles the timeline, sending Tabitha and Dakota home ("Right Person, Wrong Time").

In the following act, Tabitha has the time of her life in 21st Century Galilee with alternative hip hop ("Passing By, Running Behind"). Meanwhile, Dakota is stuck in the 1st Century and meets Tabitha's father. Dakota finds a pile of basswood and carves an oud ("Keep Tabs (on Your Heart)"). Tabitha stumbles upon a music history museum where she finds this oud with iTab & Coda!'s melodic line carved in it. With the help of Dakota's mother, who recognizes the handwriting, she steals the oud ("The Songs Linger (Long Enough)"). They are stuck in a time limbo with nothing around, but they got a second chance together ("Seconds Count").

Outside spacetime, Eternity finds the timeline is warped out of shape. They have enough of the chaos and must do a reboot. While firing the Conductor, Eternity finds out the Conductor is in cahoots with the lovebirds. Eternity takes the Conductor's baton and stabs them with it. Eternity orders the Timepipers to kill the rest of the Timeharmonic Orchestra ("Out of Wack").

Meanwhile, Tabitha and Dakota jump around time in a chaotic fashion. Tabitha reveals she knows of the Timepipers and their guitars transcend their powers. If they go back in time in "the outside world" and stop Eternity from killing the Conductor, they can save the timeline but ultimately be separated ("Paradox"). They go and save the Timeharmonic Orchestra. Their last performance is a dance with Eternity singing ("In Loving Destiny").

Back in the 21st Century, Dakota and their mother visit the music museum near Galilee. They stare at a guitar with a iTab & Coda!'s melodic line intently. The museum closes, not without the alarm blaring ("From the End"). Tabitha and Dakota reunite, this time in the Baroque period. Tabitha jokes: "If it's not Baroque, don't fix it." Dakota emphasizes how much better it would be if the next vacation is in the Renaissance. The Timeharmonic Orchestra are once again in chaos ("In Loving Destiny (Reprise)").

PLOT SUMMARY (SCENE-BY-SCENE)

Act I

Scene 1: The cosmic timeline remains balanced through the constant performances of the Timeharmonic Orchestra, overseen by Eternity Linger and the three shapeshifting bird-like Timepipers: Frailty (Past), Reality (Present), and Destiny (Future).

Scene 2: In 1st Century Galilee, a lyre maker named Tabitha longs for an individualistic sound. Meanwhile, in 21st Century Michigan, a guitar maker named Dakota isolates themselves by clinging purely to ancient music. Both of their families view them as failures.

Scene 3: Annoyed by Reality's strict rules, Frailty and Destiny decide to play Cupid. Destiny gives Tabitha American basswood for an oud, and Frailty gives Dakota ancient Judean date palm seeds for their guitar. When strummed, the wood and seeds warp space-time, trapping both musicians in the 19th Century.

Scene 4: Tabitha and Dakota initially clash bitterly over their chronological differences. Meanwhile, outside of time, Reality discovers the rift and warns the other Timepipers that if they don't get the humans home, Eternity will fire the Conductor and wipe the timeline completely.

Scene 5: Trying to play together to trigger a way home, Tabitha and Dakota keep accidentally jumping through different years, driving the pursuing Timepipers crazy. Their anomalies accidentally ignite the real-world historical Romantic era movement and inspire the creation of the classical guitar. Forming a duo named “¡Tab & Coda!,” they integrate modern music with ancient hymns, slowly falling in love.

Scene 6: The Timepipers track down Tabitha, seeding her mind with existential doubts about her mortality. Though Tabitha wants a future with Dakota, Dakota's inner identity crisis stalls their relationship. Suddenly, Eternity violently intervenes, tearing the timeline apart and forcefully banishing Tabitha and Dakota back to their original centuries.

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Act II

Scene 1: The separation has a twist: Tabitha is accidentally thrown into the 21st Century, where she thrives in alternative hip hop. Meanwhile, Dakota is stranded in 1st Century Galilee. With Tabitha's father, Dakota finds a stash of remaining basswood and carves a brand-new oud.

Scene 2: In the 21st Century, Tabitha visits a music history museum and uncovers a preserved historical oud. She spots the distinct signature melodic line of ¡Tab & Coda! carved right into the wood. With the help of Dakota's modern-day mother, who validates her child's handwriting, Tabitha steals the artifact from the museum, successfully tearing a rift into a void-like time limbo where she and Dakota happily reunite.

Scene 3: Outside of time, Eternity completely loses patience with the warped reality. They fire the Conductor. Discovering the Conductor was secretly helping the lovers, they brutally stab the Conductor with their own baton. Eternity turns tyrannical, ordering the Timepipers to massacre the remaining members of the Timeharmonic Orchestra.

Scene 4: Tumbling wildly through chaotic eras, Tabitha realizes their magical instruments can transcend the orchestra's cosmic powers. They must travel to the outer world, alter history, and save the Conductor from Eternity. The catch is that fixing the timeline will permanently force them back into their separate home eras. They make the leap, successfully fighting back and defending the Orchestra in a final performance.

Scene 5: Back in the safe 21st Century, Dakota and their mother visit a music museum near Galilee, staring longingly at the guitar containing the "¡Tab & Coda!" inscription. As the museum closes, the alarms blare out. Suddenly, the timeline fractures again: Tabitha and Dakota are instantly reunited in the Baroque Period. The Timeharmonic Orchestra collapses back into beautiful, chaotic disarray around them.

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SAMPLE SCENE

(Reality stares at the timeline as Frailty and Destiny giggle.)

REALITY: You two cannot be going around playing Cupid!!!

FRAILITY: Cupid won't knowth, DESTINY: They ain't gonna know,
they're on a journey. They've they're on vacay.
started something extraordinary. I ship iTab & Coda!.

REALITY: We've got to get Tabitha and Dakota back in their timelines, or
it'll be our own pasts, presents, and futures on the line!

DESTINY: (acting cute) Eternity ain't gonna take it out on us...

FRAILITY: They will ensure the Conductor won't see tomorrow, or
yesterday, or today.

(The Conductor stops conducting.)

REALITY: Keep conducting! You heard nothing.

DESTINY: What happens if that happens?

REALITY: The timeline will be erased, and Madam/Sir Eternity will take it to
the Higher Ups to reorchestrate history.

FRAILITY: Gone will be my trees and dolls...

REALITY: My toy boats and model trains...

DESTINY: My followers on TikTok...

(Frailty and Reality stare down Destiny.)

DESTINY: It's what I named my cuckoo clock...

REALITY: The Higher Ups will not make a Tyrannosaurus Rex the same way.

FRAILITY: They could do without the feathers this time.

DESTINY: Dead-tex. They had feathers?!!! So demure...

REALITY: You were on TikTok cuckoo clock when you shoulda paid attention.